POLITICS RETURNS TO THE RELIGION SYLLABUS

The BJP turns on the heat in Telangana with a new 'school jihad' narrative—viral episodes lend ammunition as election season nears

By **Prasad Nichenametla**

HOW COMPELLING IS THE IMAGE OF ISLAMIC proselytisers at large in Telangana in 2026—a region that counted a nearly 90 per cent Hindu population after 224 years of Nizam rule? That depends on the listeners, and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) is hoping there will soon be enough of those willing to be spooked by the spectre of 'school jihad'. A couple of incidents, amenable to such framing to differing degrees, have come its way in time for the Hyderabad civic elections due later this year. Toss in some trouble over religious slogans on the back of an autorickshaw, and it has enough to get going a campaign against what it portrays as the "anti-Hindu agenda" of the Congress government.

In another time and place, it may have been possible to see the first incident as an act of pedagogical value rather than an infraction: a Hindi teacher was found teaching Urdu to primary grade students at a private school. Huma Hania, the teacher in question, apparently deepened her crime by encouraging kids to greet each other with an "*aadaab*"! The matter was raised by parents of Hindu students who found Urdu words written in their wards' notebooks. That blew up.

BJP leaders and Hindutva activists held protests at Bharath Chandra School in Perkit, where it had happened. Nearby Armoor, a small town in north Telangana's Nizamabad district near, stayed tense for days. Police registered a case against the representatives of the school management, including A. Mallaiah and principal Amir Khan. BJP town president Mandula Balu and others were also booked for allegedly assaulting Khan within the school premises during a confrontation over the matter.



Takeaways

- **A Hyderabad school is in the eye of storm after a primary grade Hindu kid gets 'Islamic homework'**
- **BJP leaders also rake up a row over Urdu/Hindi in a Nizamabad school**
- **Incidents a "godsend" before civic body polls, says a BJP leader**



WRONG NOTE Police at the Success School; top left, the offending message from the Class 2 student's diary

QURAN FOR HOMEWORK

The bigger controversy came in mid-July in Hyderabad's Saidabad, which lies within the Malakpet assembly segment in the Old City, held by Asaduddin Owaisi's All India Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen (AIMIM). Here, family members complained that a teacher at Success School had prescribed Quranic verses as mandatory learning material to a primary grade Hindu pupil. The diary of a Class 2 Hindu student, who happened to be the lone non-Muslim in class, contained generic assignments of Quran-based homework—like 'Read Kalma', 'Read Surah Fatiha'.

Supriya Goud, an aunt of the child, made a video statement confronting the school management. The video went viral, and the school management immediately terminated the services of the teacher, calling it a minor lapse. Supriya did not buy that entirely. "When questioned, the principal initially claimed religious teaching was mandatory for all the students. How can it be?" she asked, speaking to media. "Is Bhagavad Gita also taught to everyone?" She saw the teacher's actions as "attempts to brainwash" a young child.